

X-Band Power Amplifier for Next Generation Networks Based on MESFET

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Abstract: Advanced wireless standards of communication like 3GPP and LTE are becoming more and more efficient and with this evolution of communication systems mobile equipment is also become smaller and smaller. Power amplifier designing has become a very crucial task in this era where efficiency and size are the main concern of any designer. In this paper we have design and analyzed X-band Class E Metal-semiconductor field effect transistor (MESFET) based Power Amplifier. This device targets the devices which use OFDM technique to improve their spectral efficiency for the next generation communication systems. Microstrip lines are used to achieve small size for our design instead of lumped components. Load Pull measurements are used to get MESFET input and output impedances optimum values. For linear and non linear operation small signal mathematical model of the design is used. To reduce thermal losses FR4 substrate is used to increase PA efficiency. Our designs shows small values of input and output return loss of about -22.3dB and -23.716 dB achieving a high gain of about

25.6 dB respectively, with PAE of about 30 % having stability factor greater than 1 and 21.894dBm of output power.

Keywords: MESFET; X-band; Power Amplifier; Advance Design System; PAE; LTE

I. INTRODUCTION

Power amplifiers are basically designed by balancing the basic three requirements i.e. efficiency, linearity and bandwidth. But when PA is used in high power applications efficiency is the main concern for a designer. Class E,F are the most commonly used high efficiency PA for which 100 percent theoretical efficiencies may be achieved but at the cost of most common three basic factors i.e. linearity, gain and bandwidth [1][2]. Despite of their advantages in high efficiency category they have limited advantages when it comes to the high radio frequency applications such as in microwave communications where this system makes use of the large bandwidth sacrificing its signal strength [3]. The improvement in efficiency of power amplifiers reduces power consumption

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In order to improve their spectral efficiency for the next generation communication systems, the authors designed a Class E Power amplifier for X Band operation.

and thus diminishes the requirements for heat sink and in turns increases efficiency/performance. A power amplifier consumes major part of power in wireless communication. In order to improve efficiency class-E amplifier is used because of its switching operation, high efficiency at high frequency above 2GHz [4][5]. Gallium Arsenide Field Effect transistor [GaAs] is very important device for X-band frequencies because of its stability and power efficiency for low power requirements. For power amplifier and oscillators design GaAs MESFET is an ideal device. In order to design a power amplifier in ADS its linear behavior should be checked first. Therefore various forms of analytical models have been developed in order to understand the behavior of MESFETs [6]. The most important things for FETs linear operation are its drain-source and gate-source voltage characteristics. The simulation results for S parameter which are frequency dependent and linear properties such as maximum gain, stability are affected by the charge model accuracy [7].

The main aim of this paper is to design and analyze PA which will operate in the portable next generation communication devices and will be used as solid-state transmitter in the terminal stage. The main approach and design is entirely dependent on S-parameters [8]. As we know that load and source terminations are complex impedances so stability is achieved by the conductance which results by the transformation of load and source terminations of

the matching circuits [9]. Today the industry is focusing to use 5g communication systems, in future the X-band will be a valuable region of frequency interms for high speed wireless communications. In the era of high speed communication system, the design of a power amplifier is the most crucial thing. Although modern transistors like HEMT and PHEMT can provide far better results than MESFET but they are quite expensive [10]. In MESFETS devices the peak drain to source will occur when the gate voltage reaches about zero which means that these devices work in the depletion mode. The device current reaches to zero as the gate voltage becomes more and more negative. There are two basic parameters which should be kept in mind while designing a MESFET PA, these are the pinch-off voltage and the maximum current. For a system to provide steady performance the drain current of the system must be controlled to adjust the gain and PAE [11].

The next generation communication devices use polar modulators in which the bias tracking of power amplifier is instantaneous and controlled by modulating the supply voltage. The input signal is converted into envelope and phase signals. Further the phase signal goes to the input of power amplifier while the envelop signal moves to the supply of the power amplifier. Eventually, both phase and envelop information are combined at the power amplifier stage.

II. MESFET ARCHITECTURE DESCRIPTION

As shown in fig.1 a partially depleted MESFET cross section is shown. An important step while designing a MESFET is incorporation of the silicide layer for making spacers between the source-gate and between gate-drain which also helps in preventing shorting, which may occur between its three terminals and thus giving high breakdown advantage to the MESFET [12][13].

In this process a Schottky gate was created by adding metal silicide step over n-well

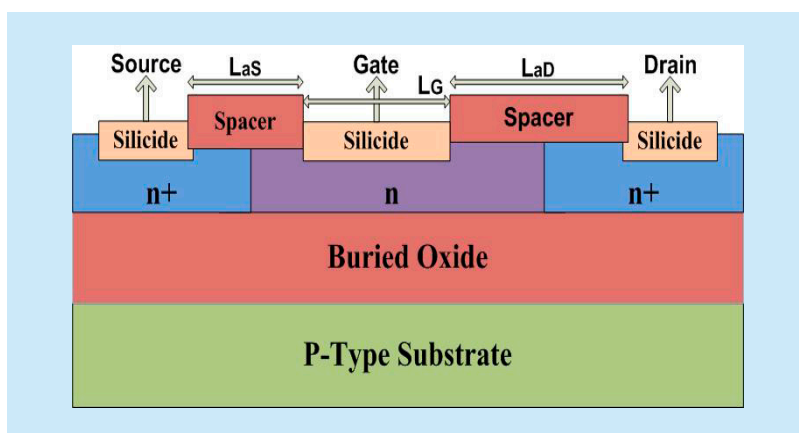


Fig. 1 MESFET cross-section [12]

which is lightly doped ss shown in fig.1. The Gate length is LG which is the distance between the two spacers and LaD is spacers length to the drain and the access length is defined by LaS , the spacing and sizing of LaD and LaS are the most important parameters that defined the MESFETS performance [14].

High voltage characteristics of the MESFETs are due to its Schottky gate. Schottky gate can handles very high amount of current flow. MESFETs devices avoid snapback and high electric field gate oxide breakdown which is because there is no thin gate oxide and it is the major cause for failure in MOSFETs [15][16]. In MESFETS the major cause of its breakdown is due to tunneling and avalanche ionization. As soft breakdown reaches in MESFETS, the surface electric field becomes large and the barrier height becomes lower at gate thus allowing the electrons to tunnel from the gate metal to the channel [17][18]. By increasing LaS and LaD lengths the electric fields can be reduced at gate to drain and from gate to source which will increase the break-down capability of the MESFETS [19].

III. MODELING AND SIMULATION OF MESFET

This section deals with the modeling and designing of our device and shows all the necessary simulations steps which will prove that our device is very efficient and unique.

In this design the transistor is biased at drain voltage $V_{dd}=5V$, drain current $I_d=120mA$ and gate voltage of $0.52V$. The drain characteristics and power consumption of the transistor are shown in Fig.2 and Fig.3 respectively. The device consumes 0.603 Watt power and has a very reasonable drain voltage. These parameters make it very reasonable choice for power amplifier design [20][21]. The small signal model of MESFET is shown in Fig.4. In this model we have defined all intrinsic and extrinsic parameters of MESFET [25].

In this model

R_g is Gate Resistance

L_d is Gate Inductance

R_s is Source Resistance

L_s is Source Inductance

R_d is Drain Resistance

L_d is Drain Inductance

R_i is input Resistance

R_o is output Resistance

C_{ds} is Drain-Source Capacitance

C_{gd} is Gate-Drain Capacitance

C_{sd} is Source- Drain Capacitance

IV. CIRCUIT ANALYSIS AND DESIGN

The amplifier is designed and simulated using Agilent ADS software, there are two transistors used in the design, the first transistor is setup in the common source configuration and coupled with a source follower MESFET. The reason to choose common source configuration for MESFET is that the common source configuration increases the gain of the MESFET while reducing the output noise of the amplifier. Following are the desired specifications of the amplifier.

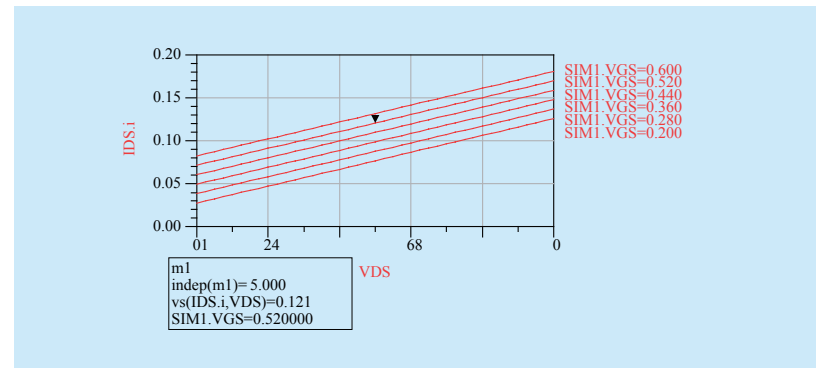


Fig. 2 Drain current versus bias curves

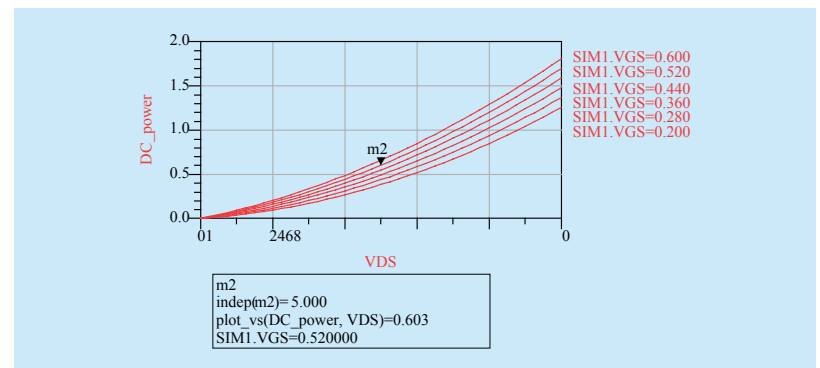


Fig. 3 DC power consumption versus bias

Table I *Amplifier Specifications*

Parameter	Desired Specification
Stability Factor	>1
Gain	More than 20 dB
Input Return Loss	More than 15 dB
Output Return Loss	More than 15 dB
Output Power	More than 20 dBm
Gain	More than 20 dB

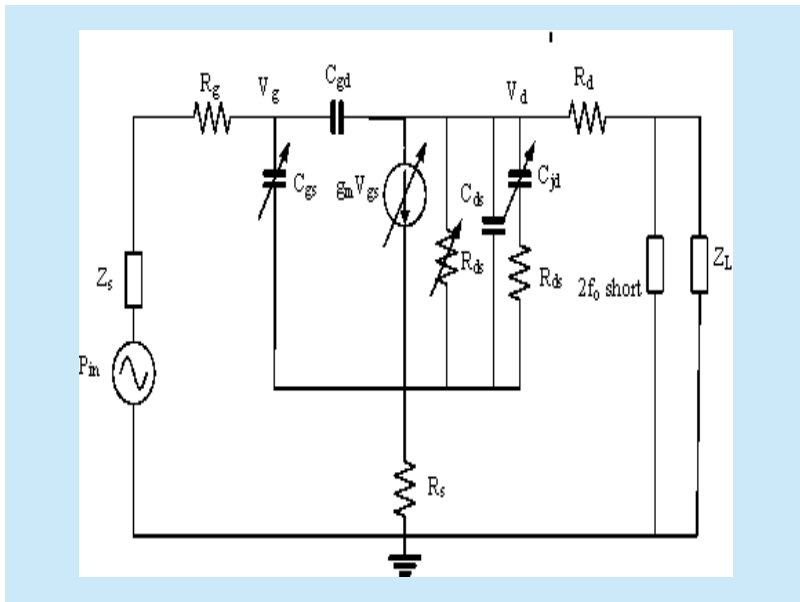


Fig. 4 *Small signal model of MESFET*

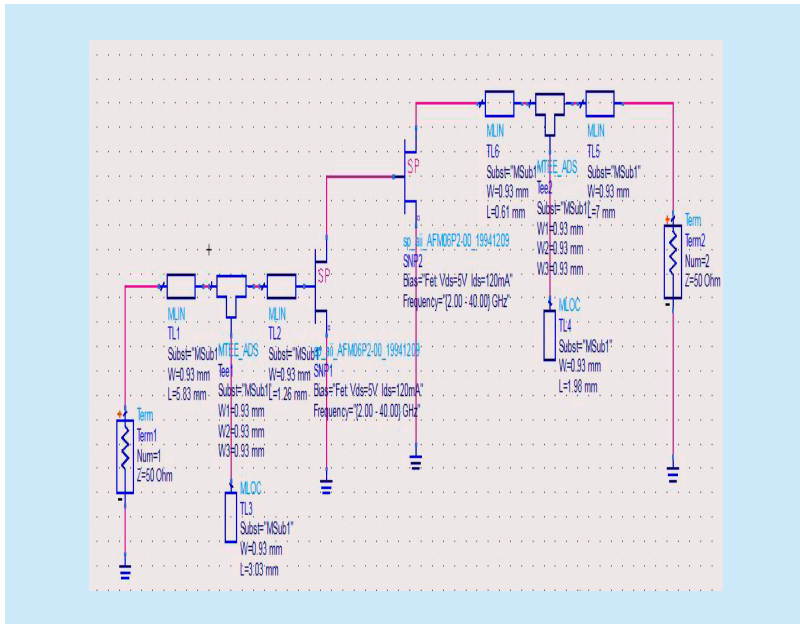


Fig. 5 *Final Design of amplifier*

Where

$$K = \frac{1 - |S_{11}|^2 - |S_{22}|^2 + |\Delta|^2}{2|S_{12}S_{21}|} \quad (1)$$

$$\Delta = S_{11}S_{22} - S_{12}S_{21} \quad (2)$$

The DC biasing network is not included in this schematic because it is an S-parameter based simulation. The optimized circuit is shown in Fig. 5

V. SIMULATION RESULTS

5.1 Stability factor

The stability factor of amplifier is shown in Fig. 6, it can be seen in the figure that the stability factor is more than 1 for the complete range of operation. Stability factor is very important in designing any type of amplifier because if this factor is below then 1, we have to implement some external stability controlling device thus increasing our cost of the device and also in turn it will increase the size of the device[24][25]. Device size is the main consideration in designing any type of power amplifier for wireless communication because now a day's mobile equipment is becoming smaller and smaller so thus the need for better, efficient and small size PA are required operating with maximum efficiency.

5.2 Input and output return losses

The lower values of input and output return losses indicate design of good impedance matching networks. The input and output matching networks are optimized using the Load pull and Source Pull matching techniques. The Load impedance of amplifier is given by

$$R_{OL} = \frac{2V_{dd}}{I_{\max}} \quad (3)$$

If the value of load impedance is less than R_{OI} then the value of power depends on max-

imum current swing. On the other hand if the value of load impedance is more than R_{OL} than power depends on maximum voltage swing of the device. The simulated results for input and output return losses are shown in Fig. 7

5.3 Gain

The amplifier power gain is given by [23].

$$G_P = \frac{\text{Power Delivered to the load}}{\text{Power input to the network}} \quad (4)$$

The transducer power gain is plotted versus fundamental output power dBm and shown in Fig. 8. It can be seen clearly that the amplifier has a transducer power gain of about 25.6 dB

The swing of input output voltage of amplifier is shown in Fig. 9

Whereas the values of output power are following

The graph of Power-Added efficiency (PAE) versus fundamental output power is shown in Fig. 10

VI. COMPARISON

Z. Ma *et al.* developed a PA using SiGe/Si HBT with lumped passive components, the amplifier has a gain of 8.7 dB, PAE of 30 % and delivers output power trip of 25 dBm [26]. Although the amplifier delivers good amount of output power and PAE but the gain of the amplifier is quite low. In [27], the author developed an 850 mW Xband SiGe power amplifier; he claims to have a gain of 13 dB with an output power of 29.3 dBm. The problem with this design is the non flat nature of gain which is very critical for a next generation communication device. In [28] Campbell *et al.* designed a compact X band amplifier using GaNFet, the amplifier

has good P_{out} dBm of 30 dBm but the device has non-flat gain. In [29] Chi *et al.* developed a power amplifier using CMOS, the amplifier achieves a gain of 14.5 dB and delivers output power of 23.8 dBm but the PAE is low for this device. In [30] the amplifier delivers large output power of 27.5 dBm but it has an extremely low gain of 5dB, the PAE is also low. The amplifier suggested in this paper provides

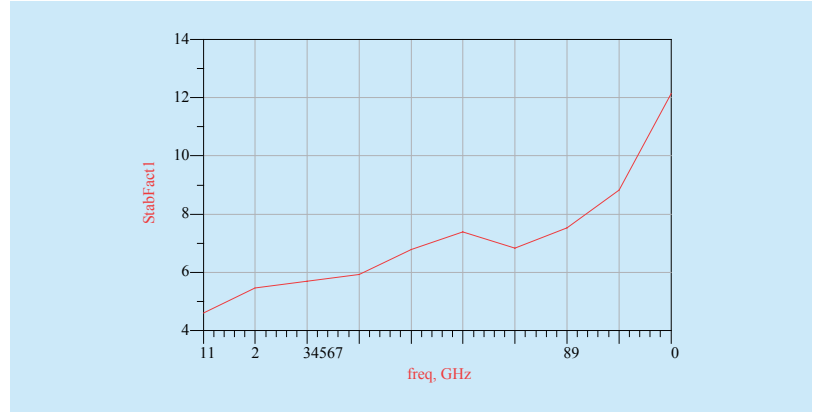


Fig. 6 Stability Factor

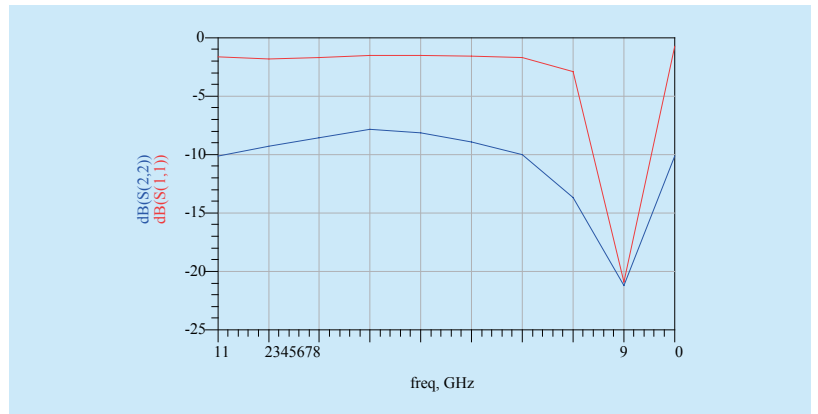


Fig. 7 Input and output return losses

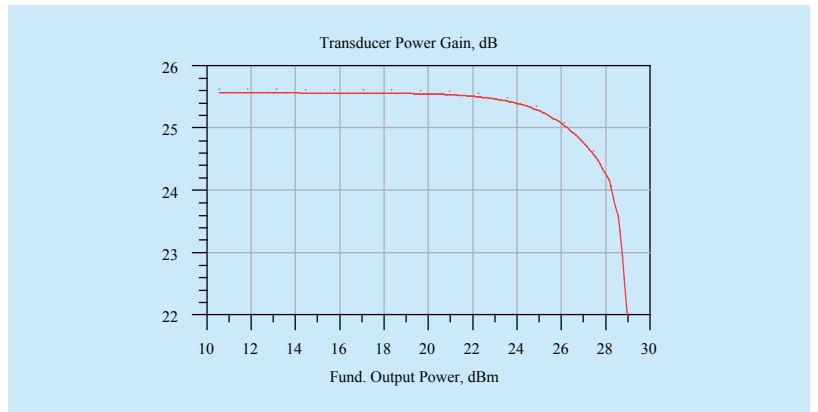


Fig. 8 Transducer Power Gain versus Output Power

a good compromise between the power delivered and the gain with a very good value of peaking PAE. The amplifier shows a flat gain of 27 dB for the entire range of operation with peaking PAE of 30 %. The flatness of gain makes this design a preferable choice for the X-band communication. Furthermore the input

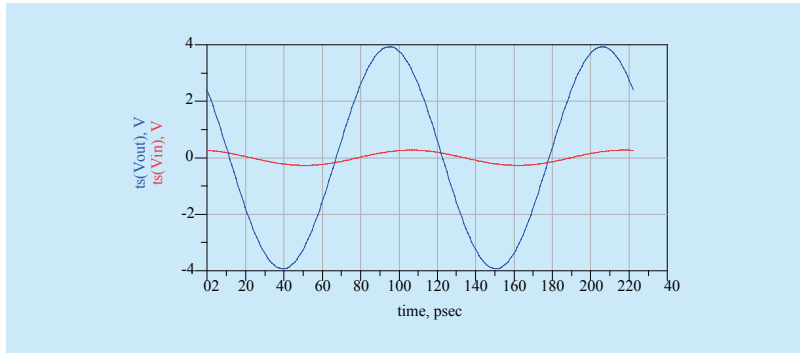


Fig. 9 Input Output Voltage

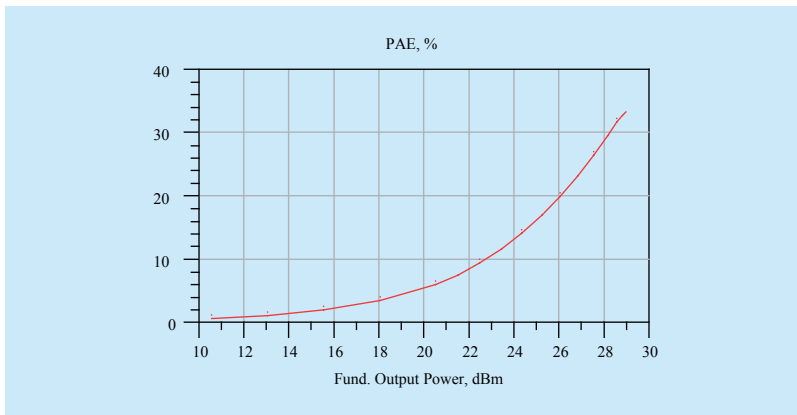


Fig. 10 Input power versus gain and output power

Table II Comparison

Reference	Gain,dB	Pout, dBm	Peak PAE(%)
This work	25.6	21.894	30
[26]	8.7	25	23
[27]	13	29.3	N/A
[28]	18	30	45
[29]	14.5	23.8	25.8
[30]	5	27.5	17.8

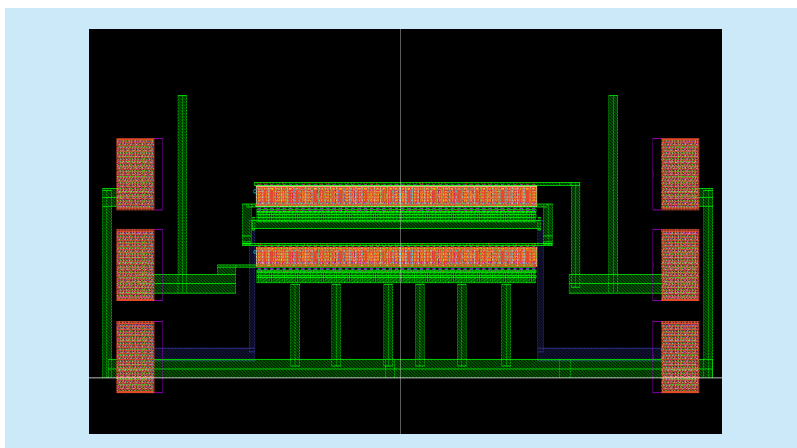


Fig. 11 Layout of power amplifier

output return losses of the amplifier are very low. The low values of return losses are result of perfectly matched matching networks. The matching networks are carefully selected and optimized at 9 GHz. The following table shows Gain vs Power output comparison of different research works and our research shows that the PA we designed is unique and has the most gain as compared to the other designs.

VII. LAYOUT OF DESIGN

The layout of power amplifier is designed in Cadence. The FR4 material is selected due to its low thermal losses as thermal losses causes decrease in efficiency of a PA. The Layout of Power Amplifier is shown in Fig. 11

VIII. CONCLUSION

In this work we designed a Class E Power amplifier for X Band operation. The device is suitable for next generation communication devices like 3GPP LTE and WiMax. The device has comparability better performance than the recently designed amplifiers in terms of gain, power delivered and Peak PAE. The design is optimized for 9 GHz frequency of operation. The amplifier is designed using Microstrip Lines to reduce the size. The Microstrip Lines are non-radiating and do not show a complex impedance behavior like inductors and capacitors. The design has a high gain of about 25.6 dB, the PAE has peaking value of 30 %. The values of input and output return losses are about 22 dB which shows the accurately designed impedance matching network.

Note

In this paper we have design and analyzed X-band Class E MESFET based Power Amplifier. We have designed and analyzed the PA and showed that our design is more efficient as compared to previous design as shown in the simulated results.

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